schoolmaster, Derek Randall, in throwing the ball away in similar circumstances.

Swanny spent the next hour pleading for the ball, promising undying love or never-ending enmity. He was wasting his breath. I made great play of offering him a ball, and he chased me around the changing room when he discovered it was a random practice ball. I'm not one for memorabilia, but I instantly formed plans for it to be mounted and given pride of place in my house. I didn't realize it at the time, but I was prey to the power of posterity.

I couldn't refuse when I was asked to donate it to the Lord's Museum (on Swanny's suggestion, inevitably). On reflection, it was one of the few times that a player sees the bigger picture. Normally, you envisage little beyond the next training drill, the next catch, the next innings or the next gym session. Flower tried to get us to appreciate we were engaged in something bigger than ourselves.

He tried to accelerate culture change by connecting us with British history, and the bloodline of the England cricket team. England rugby players under Stuart Lancaster did similarly before their disappointing home World Cup in 2015. We went on a field trip to the trenches in Ypres. Celebrated former England cricketers began to do the honours, in giving caps to debutants.

Most contentiously of all, players and management teams were packed away to a five-day hardship camp in Germany, run in the hills outside Munich by Australian special-forces personnel, the morning after the Professional Cricketers' Association dinner. Phones were banned, and people answered only to their surname. An abbreviated version of their internal training programme, it was designed to break us down and build us back up again.

When I arrived late, after being granted leave of absence for my elder brother Adrian's wedding, the players looked as if they had been brutalized. They spoke with a strange mixture of horror and amusement, of regimented press-up sessions, wearing hiking boots, in the middle of the night. An hour-long exercise involving a chariot race, with teams of four carrying a teammate up a hill on an improvised platform, had obviously left its mark. I wasn't there at the time, but the lads told me that KP was ordered by the organizers to be the passenger after he complained of an Achilles problem. He was mortified by the burden he suddenly represented, but was not allowed to change his role.